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3G handsets

Some brands that are already offering 3G mobiles phones in India:

- Apple
- Blackberry
- Fly
- HTC
- i-mate
- LG
- Micromax
- Motorola
- Nokia
- PalmTreo
- Samsung
- Sony Ericsson
- Spice

Samsung Omnia, and HTC Touch are HSDPA phones. "In CDMA, 1xEVDO provides high-speed Internet on mobile phones," says Kumar.

MTNL and BSNL have already launched 3G services in India. These are being readily accepted by the urban population. The 3G spectrum auction is expected to begin soon, allowing more operators to offer 3G services, but let's see how things unfold on this front.

Recent launches

Many new handsets offering mobile Internet through GPRS and EDGE are hitting the market. The market is still open for these technologies, before 3G is completely established. "Dual-SIM GPRS handsets from Intex—IN4477 and IN4495—offer larger displays that are suitable for Internet browsing," says Choudary. Nokia 2G phones are robust and offer good connectivity to the Internet.

Micromax is launching the H360, a 3G HSDPA phone with MTNL service, for a price as low as Rs 5500. The Micromax H365 is another 7.1cm touchscreen 3G HSDPA phone that is coming out soon, according to Jain.

Fly launched the first 3G 1xEVDO smartphone named Ivory in India along with MTS. It has a full touch display with a maximum download speed of 3.6 MBps. Fly is also working on 3G GSM phones and Android phones, which are eagerly awaited.

Affordability factor

A study shows that 50 per cent of mobile phone users use the Internet, out of which 80 per cent comprise the youth. In this segment, affordability of high-speed Internet becomes an important criteria for the handset manufacturers as well as the service providers.

"Affordability is the cost-to-value equation. If the absolute cost is higher, the value benefit will be exponentially greater. If the value is worth the price, the question of affordability is taken care of," says Kumar. "When we talk about what customers should get, we should compare the value benefits and not just the absolute numbers," he adds.

"In India, no operator subsidises the cost of mobile phones like they do in the US, where the cost of phone is recovered in a year or so," says Jain. "The potential is there in the network; there are many services and applications and it's just a matter of bringing down the price barrier," he adds.

"Many players are studying the market needs and are trying to come up with an affordable device," says Choudary. Service operators are offering different plans and packages for 3G services. Some of them are data plans of a fixed amount and some involve users paying for the volume of data transferred.

The 2G technology GPRS efficiently uses limited bandwidth to send and receive small data packets. EDGE is a faster version of GPRS and can be considered as 2.5G technology. These phones are good for e-mail and Web browsing applications. But if you are looking for a phone to watch the IPL on the move, you should opt for 3G. WCDMA, HSDPA, 1xEVDO all operate in 3G and offer high-speed downloads. These high-data rates are capable of delivering high-quality audio and video on the move for a wireless mobile handset. ●

The author is senior journalist, technology, at EPY